

ALONG THE SIDELINES

EDWIN POPE

The Long Way to the Polo Grounds, Or, Panko and the House of Rothschild

Emil Panko drives a cab in Yonkers, N.Y., during the fall and winter. He hauls a few passengers the 15 miles in to Yankee Stadium or the Polo Grounds but flatly refuses to attend a game either place.

"You ever see a guy doing something you think you can do just as well . . . but he's doing it and you're not?" he asks, a little embarrassed. "You hate to watch, don't you? Well, I don't like to watch big-league games because it kills me not to be playing in them myself."

At his present pace, Emil Panko shouldn't fret. He'll be at the Polo Grounds soon enough, in the dug-out reserved for visiting teams such as the Pittsburgh Pirates. For these days Panko is turning outfield fences into kindling as the prime slugger of the Pittsburgh-affiliated New Orleans Pelicans. The Crackers stopped him with one hit in three games last week but Clyde King's pitchers will have their fingers crossed whenever the bullshouldered right-hander steps up there in this Ponce de Leon Park series. Even with the slump, Panko is hitting .354 and is tied for the Southern Assn. lead in home runs with nine.



Pope

It is curious in some respects that Panko still is playing in the minors. It is equally curious that he has been able to come so far so quickly. The New Orleans left fielder has run into more road-blocks than Little Orphan Annie and, believe it or not, he still wears a baseball suit only by the indirect grace of the House of Rothschild.

—The Doc Gave Him Pills for Flat Feet

Go back to the beginning. The Pittsburgh Pirates signed him out of a Yonkers trade school in 1953. He got off to a stumbling start at Batavia in the Pony League, yet wound up with 102 runs batted in and a .320 average. He started slowly again in 1954 and that time it lasted: he played only 99 games for Williamsport in the Eastern League, had only 48 RBIs.

"Then last year," he says, "I figured was the end. I had all kinds of trouble. I had flat feet, and the doctor gave me some pills for them. . . ."

How's that again?

"I mean," he grins, "I was walking wrong, and my back muscles were too tight. The pills relaxed my muscles."

They had just the opposite effect on Panko's pitching foemen. He finished at .306 with 24 homers and another 102 RBIs.

Over the winter Panko was sold to Hollywood. "Then Hollywood sold me to New Orleans. That killed me. I figured I'd have had a good shot straight to the Pirates from Hollywood. But when I got to camp with the Pels I found more guys go up from New Orleans than Hollywood."

He felt pretty good—for a week. Then homesickness set in. He packed and went home to Yonkers. He said he was through with baseball.

—He Made an Enemy Out of Bob Friend

Panko looks a little like Leon Hardeman, the old all-America halfback at Georgia Tech. But Panko's face is more mobile, and it takes on a look of wonder when he describes what happened next.

"This fellow Rothschild walks into our place in Yonkers. You've heard of the House of Rothschild . . . diamonds, jewels. Well, the big gun in it was this guy's grandpa. This guy coming to see me is Joseph Rothschild. He tells me he's worked his way up from the bottom, and he knows how I feel."

"He's a big Pirates fan for some reason. He says he wants to see me playing for them some day. So he talks me into going back to New Orleans."

A few days after rejoining Andy Cohen's Pels, even out of shape at 210 pounds, Panko teed off on Bob Friend for a home run, triple and three singles in an exhibition. Since then his frame of mind has been healthy.

"This is crazy," he says, "me hitting like this. I'm supposed to be a slow starter. Last year I didn't hit a homer the first three weeks, and already I've got nine."

"But I'll try to keep it up. I'm learning. I want to make the big leagues. I don't want to be driving that cab all my life."

What he means is he wants to go to the Polo Grounds as a baseball-playing passenger, not a baseball-playing cab driver. And he probably will.